

Bosnia & Herzegovina



A mountainous country that, after a civil war, is in effect an international protectorate.

168 BCE The Romans subjugate Illyria, including the territory of modern-day Bosnia–Herzegovina.

476 CE After the collapse of the Western Roman Empire the area is conquered, in turn, by the Byzantine Empire, the Huns, Bulgars, and the Avars, who bring Slavs to the area as vassals.

1180 Kulin, a member of the heretical Christian Bogomils, rules a prosperous Bosnia, despite a Catholic crusade that is waged by Hungary on the church's behalf against Bogomilism in the Balkans.

1254 Bela IV asserts the authority of the Hungaro–Croatian kings over part of Bosnia.

1322 Stepan II Kotromanic becomes ruler of a Bosnia subject to Hungary.

1353 Kotromanic's nephew Tvrtko succeeds his uncle and, with Serbia in decline, increases Bosnia's territory. In 1377 he is crowned king of Serbia, Bosnia, Croatia, and the coast, despite failing to prevent an Ottoman Turkish victory over the Serbs at Kosovo in 1389.

1463 Ottomans conquer Bosnia and, in 1492, capture Herzegovina (which takes its name from the title herceg—duke—assumed by its ruler Stevan Vukcic in 1448). Significant sections of the population convert to Islam. Bosnia becomes a key outpost for the Turks in their European wars.

1697 The Hungarian prince Eugene captures Sarajevo from the Turks. Under the Treaty of Karlowitz in 1699 Bosnia is divided between the Ottoman and Habsburg Empires.

1831 Hussein Kapetan, the “Dragon of Bosnia,” rebels against the Turks. After occupying territory in Macedonia and Bulgaria, he is defeated and exiled.

1875 An insurrection against Turkish rule in Herzegovina spreads to Bosnia and is supported by Serbs and Montenegrins. Serbia, which has long aspired to unification with Bosnia, declares war on the Turks, but is swiftly defeated. Austria–Hungary occupies Bosnia–Herzegovina and the Sandzak of Novi Pazar, a narrow strip of land separating Serbia from Montenegro, after Turkey's defeat in the Russo-Turkish war of 1877–78.

1908 Austria–Hungary annexes Bosnia–Herzegovina, with tacit agreement from Russia, weakened by the 1905 revolution and war with Japan. The Sandzak is restored to the Ottoman Empire. Without Russian support, can do nothing and the annexation is recognized by the major European powers in April 1909.

1914 Gavrilo Princip, a Bosnian Serb revolutionary of the Black Hand secret society, assassinates the Austrian archduke Franz Ferdinand, heir to the emperor Franz-Josef, and his wife in Sarajevo, the Bosnian capital. An Austrian ultimatum is rejected by Serbia and the war between them spreads across Europe.

1918 National committee is formed in Sarajevo after the defeat of Austria–Hungary. Bosnia is united with Serbia in the kingdom of Serbs, Croats, and Slovenes. A period of democracy follows, marred by ethnic disputes.

1929 Dictatorship is imposed by King Alexander in attempt to end nationalism. The country is renamed Yugoslavia.

1941 Germany invades Yugoslavia. Bosnia and Herzegovina are assigned to Croatia, under the rule of the fascist Ante Pavelic and his Ustase Party. Rival partisan groups form to offer resistance: the Serbian royalist Chetniks and the communist Partisans under Josef Broz Tito, leader of the Communist Party of Yugoslavia, which forms a provisional government in 1943.

1945 Tito's provisional government abolishes the monarchy and in 1946 proclaims the Federal People's Republic of Yugoslavia, in which Bosnia and Herzegovina is one of the six constituent republics. In the 1960s, the Muslims are deemed to constitute a “nation.”

1972 Trials of nationalists begin in Sarajevo in the wake of an increase in ethnic tension throughout Yugoslavia.

1980 Tito dies and is replaced by an eight-person, rotating collective leadership from each republic and province. In Bosnia–Herzegovina the local regime is characterized by corruption and authoritarianism.

1990 Bosnian nationalists defeat communists in multi-party elections, which are won by the Party of Democratic Action (SDA), led by Alija Izetbegovic, who becomes president after independence.

1991 Slobodan Milosevic of Serbia and Franjo Tudjman agree secretly to divide Bosnia between their two countries.

1991 Bosnian parliament announces republican sovereignty but remains within Yugoslavia.

1992 Bosnians vote in a referendum for independence, which is recognized by the EU and US. Serbs declare “Republika Srpska,” an independent Serbian republic, in Bosnia. A three-sided civil war begins with Muslims defending themselves against both Croat and Serb forces. Elsewhere an uneasy coalition of Muslims and Serbs fight the Croats. The war is marked by Serb and Croat brutality.

1992 The UN intervenes by taking over Sarajevo airport to fly in relief supplies,

DECISIVE MOMENT

WAR CRIMES TRIBUNAL IS ESTABLISHED, 1993

On May 25, 1993, the UN Security Council approved the foundation of the International Criminal Tribunal for the former Yugoslavia, with the aim of prosecuting crimes committed in the Bosnian war. The Bosnian Serb commander Dusko Tadic (right) was sentenced to 20 years in prison for crimes against the Muslims in Omarska and other detention camps. The court has given a voice to thousands of victims who have testified as witnesses against defendants.



and imposes sanctions. It also condemns “ethnic cleansing” by Serbs of Muslims and Croats from parts of Bosnia, and approves the use of force to restore peace.

1993 UN establishes “safe havens” for Muslims.

1994 Muslims and Croats form federation in Herzegovina, while NATO begins air strikes against Bosnian Serb positions.

1995 Bosnian Serb troops kill 8,000 Muslims in Srebrenica. Croatian–Bosnian offensive wins back significant areas.

1995 A peace deal brokered by US President Clinton is reached at Dayton, Ohio, between the presidents of Serbia, Bosnia, and Croatia. The agreement sets up two separate states within Bosnia—the Muslim–Croat Federation, and Republika Srpska—operating underneath a three-community rotating presidency and a two-chamber representative federal parliament. A UN High Representative retains ultimate control of the country.

1995 The NATO international IFOR contingent takes over peace-keeping duties from the UN, and is replaced in 1996 by SFOR, a “Stabilization Force.”

1996 First international war crimes trial since 1945 opens in the Hague.

1998–2000 Elections show continued support for nationalist parties.

2001 Ethnic Croats briefly establish autonomy in Herzegovina (in south).

2004 EU takes over peace-keeping duties, although the UN retains control.

2005 Leaders of the three main ethnic groups agree to a series of constitutional reforms to enhance the authority of the Bosnian government, streamlining the federal presidency and parliament, and reducing the powers of the federal states.

2006 Bosnia joins NATO's Partnership for Peace program, a precursor to full NATO membership.

2008 Former Bosnian Serb leader Radovan Karadzic is arrested in Belgrade and sent to the Hague for trial (which begins in 2009). In Bosnia, nationalist parties win largest vote share in elections, cementing ethnic divisions.

2010 Parties favoring Bosnian unity do well in Croat and Bosnian Muslim areas in general elections, but nationalist parties top the polls in Serb areas.

«198–99 The Byzantine Empire
«246–47 The Ottoman Empire
«450–51 War in Yugoslavia

Rebuilding bridges

In 1993 the destruction by Bosnian Croats of the 16th-century bridge linking Croat and Muslim communities on either side of the River Neretva in Mostar symbolized the collapse of Bosnia itself. The bridge (below) has been painstakingly restored.

